



A MORE PERFECT UNION

AN EMPEROR'S CHILDREN SHORT STORY

RICH MCCORMICK



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A MORE PERFECT UNION

Rich McCormick

A soul-light, brighter than the rest. Not just brighter, but closer too, close enough to reveal itself as a vessel for countless smaller lights. They twinkle like a tiny galaxy, even through the gloom.

She taps at the glass, once, twice. *Come here, little galaxy*, she says. *I can show you such pleasure.*

It always started like this. The world was Harmony. An appropriate name. The sky was alive with swirls of pink and wisps of purple, pearl-white clouds layered on a turquoise horizon. It was beautiful, until it started falling.

A chunk of pure hatred, called forth from the void and hurled at Canticle City, whose screaming spires stood as a testament to the glory of the Emperor's Children. The purple sky curdled, turning dark like a bruise, before it disappeared entirely.

Xantine looked up and stared at a dark mass the size of a city, wreathed in a halo of yellow fire, falling from the void. Black and gold, come to annihilate him.

The planet shook, and the towers – monuments to excess, to obsession, to beauty – toppled. A chunk of purple marble, polished to a perfect shine, fell across his body. Xantine lay, speared in place like an insect on a specimen table.

And then, a tug under his arms. Soft, it felt, like the touch of silk on skin. The ache in his legs dissipated. He was lifted up in gentle arms.

'Xantine. We must go,' said a voice.

Go? Go where? he wondered. His legs were shattered. The sky had vanished. Where could he escape to?

A tug again, harder this time, jolting him upwards. He looked down at the purple-armoured arms pulling his body up to a standing position.

‘Xantine.’

He looked up again at his Legion’s destroyer.

Xantine. This was another voice, a different voice. He was stumbling now, cradled in the crook of his rescuer’s arm, but he heard it, soft on the wind, yet somehow audible over the sound of the city’s death scream.

It was a voice of aching, of longing, of cloying desire. He felt it in the base of his neck, a frisson of delight in the darkness.

‘*Xantine!*’ This third voice was much less pleasant: harsh, metallic and accompanied by a cold blast of liquid. Xantine opened his eyes, tracing his long tongue around swollen lips, tasting something sweet.

Perilymph wine. A good vintage, too – good enough that he knew it could only belong to one individual on board this ship. Euphoros, warlord of the Children of Torment, and eminent power aboard the frigate *Exhortation*. Xantine steeled himself and opened turquoise eyes.

‘It has been some time since you made your way to my bedchamber, my lord,’ he said, draping a purple cloak around his naked body and drawing himself up to standing height with a predator’s grace.

Euphoros stood in the centre of Xantine’s quarters, his glassy black eyes staring, unblinking, from their pits in a puckered, inflamed face. ‘Truly it has, Xantine, my dear boy,’ he said, through a fang-ridged mouth that ran from ear to ear. His elaborate armour was heavily modified from the original form, decorated with barbed spines, engraved with scenes of debauchery, and festooned with golden tassels. It was largely painted black, except for a handful of panels that had been rendered in purple and mother-of-pearl.

He was different, once. The Euphoros Xantine had known had been a proud warrior of the III Legion who tried to strike out on his own after the destruction of Harmony, bringing with him a small warband of dispossessed Emperor’s Children who had escaped the collapse of their fortress-city. For a time, Euphoros succeeded, raiding and reaving with Xantine at his side

along the fringes of the Chinchare Subsector.

But now the Legion wars were over, with Abaddon's Black Legion the clear victor, and their hatred of their old rivals meant that as long as Euphoros' warband wore the imperial purple of the Third, they were harried and harassed. So Euphoros had done the unthinkable – he had cast aside his allegiance to the Emperor's Children, and joined the other worshippers of the Youngest God who chose to throw their lot in with Abaddon by taking the mantle of the Children of Torment. Xantine hated him for his decision.

'So, my lord,' Xantine asked. 'Why come now?'

'I missed you,' Euphoros replied with exaggerated affection. 'We missed you.' Euphoros gestured at the hulking figure behind him, closer to the bedchamber's ornate door. Vavisk, once captain of the Emperor's Children 37th Company, now Noise Marine of the Children of Torment, inclined his head.

'Brother,' he croaked.

Vavisk rarely wore his helmet, but still his voice came filtered through a vox-grille, the shimmering metal grown out of the remnants of his mouth after long millennia in the warp. To compensate for the loss of a sensing organ, smaller mouths had sprouted on Vavisk's neck. They opened and closed seemingly at random, whispering promises or tasting the air with fat little tongues.

'In truth, we have guests, Xantine,' Euphoros continued, pacing slowly around the opulent bedchamber. The thick carpet muffled his heavy footsteps. 'As we speak, the Black Legion cruiser *Shattered Blade* arrives in-system with guidance to an unknown world, its alien riches already claimed by the Corpse-Emperor.'

He gesticulated as he spoke, turning his long-fingered hands and raising his arms in a theatrical flourish. The servos in his ornamented plate whirred musically with each sweeping movement.

'We have operated on the fringes of Abaddon's crusade, yet we have won glories beyond compare. Finally, we have been recognised for our perfection, and now our companions in the Black Legion come to us, to bring us into the fold.' Euphoros turned, his black eyes shining. 'Just as once we were brothers of the Emperor's Children, first among equals in our father's beautiful host, once again I give us that chance – to secure our rightful place at the pinnacle of Abaddon's host, and to slake our thirsts

with the Warmaster, as true members of the Black Legion.'

This was an ultimatum, Xantine realised. Under the bluster and theatrics, Xantine understood the deeper point. What other choice did Euphoros have? Short on men and materiel, his warband would have died out with time, afflicted by the same cancer that had almost strangled the Emperor's Children at birth. To Euphoros, it was better to lap at the dregs of sensation than try to refill a spilled cup.

Xantine said nothing, and his warlord sighed. Pacing again, Euphoros made a show of inspecting the detritus he found in the bedchamber, jabbing an armoured boot at a collection of jars and containers piled up against an arming table, their lids removed and their contents drained. He bent down and plucked one from the floor. It was ceramic, etched with runes, and still rimed with frost. Euphoros cast a black-eyed glance in Xantine's direction again.

'What is it you desire, Xantine?'

Xantine considered the question. Sensation. Glory. *Revenge*. He caught his tongue between his sharpened teeth and bit down. The blooming taste of blood filled his mouth.

'To serve you, my lord.'

Euphoros waited a beat, and then clapped his hands together. Golden talons clacked as they met each other over polished breastplate. 'Good. Good! So much has changed, and yet, you remain my most faithful servant. I was worried. I hear pillow talk from souls that tell me you are lost to your...' He looked at the empty containers. 'To your predilections.'

'No, my lord,' Xantine said, and his soul rippled with the memory of the previous night's excesses. 'They are fleeting delights, nothing more.'

'How excellent!' Euphoros squealed. 'Excellent. You are very dear to me, Xantine,' he continued, his tone honeyed. 'As I must be very dear to you, as your lord, your protector.' He paused for a beat to let the words bite. 'And your saviour.'

It had been an ultimatum. Now it was a threat.

'I remember Canticle City, my boy. I pulled you from its wreckage, I gave you a home, I kept you alive. Alive to see, to taste, to touch. The past is a dead thing, its passions spent, and its colours dull. The *future*...' – Euphoros cast his hands forward as though witnessing something sublime – 'ah, there is the beauty. And with Abaddon, we have a galaxy of beauty to

gorge upon.'

The warlord didn't wait to hear Xantine's response, turning on spurred heels and walking from the chamber, his armour clinking and jangling with each movement.

Vavisk remained.

'The future!' Xantine barked a laugh. 'We have no future, so long as we remain shackled to the yoke of Abaddon's rabble.'

The Noise Marine remained silent – or as silent as he could be. Feedback thrummed from the depths of his body, while the mouths in his throat smacked and slapped their small lips together. '*Traitor*,' they seemed to sigh.

Xantine moved to his arming table and turned the armour he found there in his hands. Once it had been royal purple – the colour of nobles, of kings, of *emperors*. His new plate was black and gold. The charred black of a city burned to ash. The flaming gold of the fire at the end of the world.

'Come, Xantine,' Vavisk said, his voice a bass burr that shuddered through the walls of the opulent bedchamber. 'Our Legion awaits.'

'Our Legion is dead,' Xantine spat. 'And we go to join its killers.'

Vavisk inclined his head again, and left Xantine alone with his armour.

Once, it had been an observation deck, a place where the Space Marines of the Emperor's Children considered the stars they were sent to conquer. Now, on board the ship that had come to be called the *Exhortation*, the space was known as the Living Gallery.

The viewports had been covered with heavy drapes and tapestries of soiled material, tanned beast hide, and skin of all species. At regular intervals hung vast paintings, depictions of nightmare landscapes crawling with arachnid Neverborn, and life-size portraits, their frames containing still-living bodies stitched into stained canvas.

One depicted the fall of the aeldari. Three members of that race, their limbs broken to unnatural angles and their bodies sewn together in a lewd configuration, hung below a horned representation of Slaanesh, the Youngest God depicted in rendered human fat and other unspecified fluids. The jaws of the aeldari had been removed, leaving their teardrop-shaped eyes to gawp in wordless agony.

Another commemorated the Siege of Terra, and the Emperor's Children's

actions once they reached the planet. It had been partially covered up since Euphoros threw his lot in with the wider Black Legion, but part of the painting was still visible. It was somehow liquid, a viscous pink-grey slurry that sloshed interminably, roiling with the soul mass of thousands. Faces bubbled up to the surface, their hollow mouths cast open, before bursting with wet gurgles of pain.

Running down the centre of the room was a dais, its length raised on pillars of veined muscle that tensed and contracted to better show its occupants to their audience. It was from this dais that Euphoros' bulging, lidless eyes took in the sweep of transhumanity in front of him. They lay sprawled across chaise longues upholstered with xenos skin and human hair, or stood in loose groups, practising showy fencing manoeuvres for the entertainment of their peers. It was a panorama of coal black and burnished gold, broken by armour panels in shades of pastel pink, coral green and glossy purple.

To Xantine, entering the Living Gallery, the panels were a sad remnant of his glorious past: wild colour amongst the gloom, the darkness overtaking the light like a terminal cancer in a once flourishing organism. He surveyed the scene, before moving to stand beside Qaran Tun.

'Cousin,' Tun said, as Xantine stood at his shoulder. 'You must come to my library soon. I have some new morsels that I think you will find very interesting.'

The Word Bearer was an esoterist, consumed by the search for, and study of, new varieties of Neverborn. His prior allegiances had brought him against the Children of Torment in battle, but his passions meant that he soon discovered he had more in common with Euphoros' sense-seekers than his own Legion's dour, chanting asceticism. He seemed to accept Euphoros' defection to the Black Legion without complaint, given assurances that he would be afforded the time and space he required to indulge his interests, and willing subjects to test the diabolic arts on.

Tun and Xantine were joined by a creature a head taller than both of them. Lordling, as the warrior had come to be known, was still technically a Space Marine, but his true name had been forgotten with his transformations. He had grown vastly too fat for his power armour, and his pink belly hung swollen and heaving over the silks and skins that covered his thick legs. Atop it all sat a hairless head bearing a slit mouth that was

pulled into a permanent rictus grin, as if he found the whole galaxy impossibly amusing. He found violence most amusing of all.

‘My beautiful brothers,’ Euphoros began, accepting the attention of the warriors in the room. ‘We gather today in joy, as we take our next step towards perfection. Today we join the greater portion of Abaddon’s glorious crusade en route to a world previously unknown even to the Warmaster. Its name is Kalliope, and it has been temporarily lost to the spawn of our father’s favourite – the Iron Hands. Our Warmaster has given us the honour of throwing off the yoke of the Imperium, breaking their fortress, and returning with the spoils.’

Euphoros cast his arms to the back of the room. ‘Behold, the Black Legion!’

Blinded slaves pulled open the vast curtain at the back of the chamber, and through the opening marched a dozen warriors. These transhumans were clad in the pure black and gold of Abaddon’s Legion.

At their head stalked a giant in baroque Terminator armour, his face a ruin. The brow and nose were missing entirely, caved in by some unknown force and replaced with mechanical augmetics. A single red lens stared from the centre of the wreckage, framed by silver metal teeth that jutted up from the remnants of his lower jaw. In one hand he held a long-hafted hammer, the head of which glowed molten hot, as if lit from inside by an infernal force. He cast his glowing eye back and forth across the Children of Torment and their Living Gallery as he trudged forwards, the opulence on show a stark contrast to the brutal functionality of his form.

Xantine didn’t recognise the brute, but he knew his companion from the moment he entered the Living Gallery. The tall figure moved with a loping gait, each step punctuated with snarls, shrieks and hisses. His charcoal-black helmet was decorated with a vast plume, an amalgam of exotic feathers, dyed hair and strips of tanned skin that cascaded over his armour’s power pack. Xantine muttered his name before he unclasped his helmet. Standing in front of Euphoros, his golden-skinned features seemingly untouched by the ravages of the warp, was Epiales Kyr.

‘A brother of yours?’ Qaran Tun asked in Xantine’s ear.

‘Once,’ Xantine muttered.

Kyr had been a member of the Emperor’s Children’s 37th Company, but had fled Canticle City long before the Tlaloc reduced it to glass and ashes,

reappearing in Abaddon's employ while the rest of his former Legion licked their wounds. Xantine couldn't help but see the two events as connected.

Kyr had obviously risen far since donning the black and gold, but it was clear who was in command among the visitors. The Terminator-armoured monster lifted a huge leg as he reached the dais, hefting his fur-clad form up to stand alongside Euphoros, while Kyr and his retinue stayed below.

'Children of Torment,' Euphoros shouted, his voice melodious. 'Bid welcome to Gorenn, glorious chosen of Abaddon!' The brute surveyed the scene, his single augmented eye inscrutable.

Euphoros continued. 'Just as he has shown such generosity in allowing us to enjoy the sights and sounds of slaughter, we shall give him a gift in kind. Today we deploy the Maru Skara – the perfection of the Third' – Xantine noted that Euphoros chose not to say the Legion's name in front of the newly arrived Black Legionnaires – 'against the thin-blooded lackeys of our grandsire's throne.'

The Maru Skara. The Emperor's Children of old took the concept from the duelling cults of ancient Terra, transcribing the feint-and-thrust of individual combat to the mass warfare of the Space Marine Legions – a legacy that Euphoros took the time to demonstrate on stage. 'The open blade!' Euphoros swept his blade forward with a flourish, slicing the air. 'And the hidden blade!' In his off-hand, he stabbed forward with a jewelled dagger, turning to the crowd and bowing to frantic applause from the most sycophantic of his warriors.

Xantine knew the formation well; indeed, he was one of the few among Euphoros' Children of Torment who had been a part of it in action, but it demanded the kind of perfection and precision that only Xantine was capable of carrying out.

This was why Euphoros had come to test his resolve, then: to judge his fitness to lead the hidden blade. Even when it was deployed in service of a broken warband in the employ of a bastard Legion, command of the Maru Skara was one of the greatest honours for the Emperor's Children. A gift that his loyalty to the Third would not let him reject. Better still: a gift that could serve him. Perhaps deploying the perfect hidden blade would allow him to rise to Euphoros' side – and should their glorious lord meet his end somehow, then Xantine, with his mastery of the Maru Skara, would have Abaddon's ear and could direct his crusade to sate his tastes. The wound to

Xantine's pride began to knit itself shut, and he allowed himself to scheme. Euphoros replaced both weapons and turned his attention again to the assembled crowd. 'To strike with the hidden blade is a great honour, a role that belongs to the most perfect warrior among us.'

Xantine steeled himself for adulation.

'Epiales Kyr, my new muse – step forward.'

The golden-skinned warrior stepped proudly onto the dais, a rigid smile on his face, spittle foaming at the corner of his glistening lips.

'Kyr, our prodigal child, returns to lead us into battle!' Euphoros exclaimed, to renewed applause.

Xantine's rage was absolute – a crystalline thing, like a spear driven deep into his chest. A wound to the pride so grievous that it felt fatal. Xantine spat on the floor, the acid in his saliva fizzing and spitting as it chewed through the stained carpet, but the bile still rose in his genetically modified stomach, hot and poisonous.

He would kill Euphoros. He would kill Gorenn, the obvious power behind the Black Legion in the subsector. At that moment, he felt he would kill Abaddon, his anger so perfect that he could bring it down in a lethal blow on the Warmaster, just as he had killed the III Legion.

It was an outrage! An insult without compare, dishonour without measure. His exit from the Living Gallery had been as measured as he could muster, but now that he found himself in Qaran Tun's library, he allowed his rage to be unmasked. Xantine slammed a silk-gloved fist against the bare stone wall, his blood mingling with assorted fluids that already stained it a dark purple.

Lordling tittered, thrilled by the sudden outburst of violence, and clapped his hands over his distended belly.

'Epiales Kyr, that shrieking moron, that tasteless neophyte, given the hidden blade? What does he know of the Maru Skara? What does he know of perfection?'

Xantine had spent many lifetimes cultivating his epicurean tastes; compared to him, Kyr was a simple glutton, desperate for ragged scraps of sensation.

How did it end up like this? Following his father into Horus' rebellion had brought Xantine closer to perfection, pinning open his eyes and ears to the

pain, the pleasure and the delicious *truth* of the galaxy. The Long War let him share his joy, but now the Third had been broken, and he was forced to serve alongside barbarians.

Worse, Abaddon's crusade had been met by a counter-thrust from the hated Imperium. Guilliman, resurrected, had brought his own crusade, its ranks bolstered by monsters wearing human skin. Primaris Space Marines, as Xantine knew they were called: indoctrinated loyalists, weak shadows of Astartes that dared to wear the aquila on their breast, unearned, unremarked. This new breed were creations of a father that came so close to perfection with Fulgrim and his children, but now walked further and further from the path each day.

He punched and punched and punched again, the velvet of his gloves tearing and leaving smears of red blood across the bare stone walls. The whorls of red darkened to purple as they dried in the flickering candlelight, reminding him of the sky over Harmony. The sight calmed him for a moment.

Qaran Tun inclined his tattooed head. 'Have you finished, cousin?'

Xantine sucked in a deep breath of foetid air, and licked blood from his ragged knuckles with a long, dark tongue. 'Yes. Give me what I want.'

Tun gestured across an altar arrayed with hundreds of containers – vials, jars, barrels and amphorae – each covered in spidery runic carvings. Some juddered slightly, twitching randomly or pulsing in time with the ship's discordant rhythm; others gave off soft moaning sounds.

'As always,' Tun said. 'You may choose.'

Xantine's eyes came to rest on a small container carved from glistening black stone, its lid rimed with ice. 'That one,' he said, and assumed his usual position, draped across the stone chair at the centre of the room.

Compared to the rest of the *Exhortation*, Qaran Tun's library looked positively spartan, appearing as it did like the inside of some crude temple on a feudal world. But Xantine knew better – Tun had had the stone brought from the daemon world of Ghalmek, fashioning it into walls, altars and the austere throne in which Xantine now sat.

The Word Bearer lowered his head over the container, whispering words and performing rites of awakening, before passing it to Xantine and stepping away.

The shape that slithered out of the container was insubstantial, its form

shifting, coalescing into something almost discernible before collapsing back into shadow. It tested the air, seeming to sniff like a rodent, before it began a slow crawl up Xantine's armoured chest.

Xantine let it come, slowing his twin heartbeats and closing his eyes. He felt a familiar chill as the daemon slipped into his mind. The Traitor Marine had allowed his own soul to ebb backwards, washing quietly into the deepest recesses of his being to make room for the interloper, and now he watched it from afar. It moved slowly at first, tentatively reaching out like it was trying to manoeuvre its way across a dark room. He could sense its surprise at finding a host so apparently open to its advances, feel its glee as it started to expand into the physical form that it was sure would be its new home. Even though he was ceding control of his body, Xantine still felt the sensation run down his arms and legs, cold like ice water. His hearts skipped slightly as the consciousness got the full measure of its new transhuman host. He felt the daemon relax, felt it pulse with a wave of contentment.

Xantine floated for a moment in his helplessness, left only with a fingerhold on reality, savouring the kiss of oblivion. And then he struck.

Where he had retreated his soul before, now he reversed course, pressing in like a tidal wave on the little daemon. He felt terror, in an instant, so primal as to be perfect, so thick that even partially severed from his body, he could taste it on his slackened tongue. Terror demanded a choice of the daemon: fight, or flight. It tried the latter, but it was already too late. This was far from the first daemon Xantine had welcomed inside his being, and once they were in, he knew far better than to let them out again.

So fight, then, and fight it did, lashing out like a cornered canid. It snapped and clawed at Xantine even as the Traitor Marine drew his tattered soul up to full force; it screamed and wailed, sending out waves of abject emotion that reverberated against the fringes of Xantine's consciousness.

But what was even the most dangerous canid against the force of the ocean? Xantine weathered the strikes with pleasure, allowing himself a moment of perverse pride in the Neverborn for putting up such a fight, before he threw his full force against the creature. He withdrew only when a broken shell remained, pulling it down with him into the dark depths of his being, down to where he had lain, almost powerless and barely conscious, down to rest with the mangled remnants of those that had been destroyed in

the same manner.

Xantine opened his eyes. Their turquoise irises shone bright in the darkened chamber.

‘You return,’ Qaran Tun said. The diabolist was scrawling notes in a book bound in what Xantine had to presume was human skin. ‘But is it truly you, cousin?’

‘It is,’ Xantine sighed, his long tongue tracing his tingling lips. He flexed his shoulders, feeling corded muscle bunch and swell, and opened his senses to the ship. Music always sounded better after one of his little interludes, and one could always hear music on the *Exhortation*.

‘Most illuminating,’ Tun said, his hand moving in sharp motions as he marked dark runes across the mottled page. ‘Tell me, what did you glean from this Neverborn? What did it—’

‘Another,’ Xantine said, cutting him off.

‘You must detail the experience,’ Qaran Tun replied, setting the book down carefully. ‘That was the arrangement.’

‘Another,’ Xantine repeated, his right hand falling to the curved falchion that rested against the grey stone chair he reclined in.

Qaran Tun met his gaze, and for a moment, Xantine pondered drawing the weapon and plundering the Word Bearer’s collection for himself. But Tun’s curiosity seemed to win out. He inclined his head again, gesturing towards his altar of containers. ‘Make your choice.’

Xantine rose from his seat and made his way to the diabolist’s altar, his body – advanced by both the Emperor’s fleshcraft and the warp’s touch – recovered from his momentary possession and moving once again with sinuous grace. Tracing a long-nailed finger along the racks, he came to rest this time on a larger receptacle, tapping it twice.

‘This one,’ he said.

‘A recent vintage,’ Tun advised. ‘That one I rescued from the private collection of an aeldari corsair queen. She was loath to part with it, destroying her own ship – and her own crew – to stymie my efforts. She almost succeeded. I would have lost it during our retreat, were it not for the sacrifice of some of my flock.’ Robed figures in the shadowed alcoves of the chamber shuffled at the mention of their slain brethren. Xantine could smell their nervousness even over the fug of incense. ‘I have had little time to study its contents. Please ensure my effort was not entirely wasted.’

With two fingers on his left hand, Qaran Tun drew profane symbols against his armoured breast. With the right, he gently lifted the container, placing it with reverence into Xantine's open palms. In the gloom it had looked like clay, but now it felt more like bone, feather-light in the hands of the Astartes warrior. It was, he realised, of aeldari creation: wraithbone. A rarity.

Xantine removed the stopper, and breathed deeply, settling back in the chair to allow the container's contents to consume him. As before, there was a sliver of cold as the daemon slithered into his mind. But where his last morsel had seen an apparently empty vessel and rushed in, this one seemed to understand the trap. It danced at the edge of his consciousness, teasing and testing the boundary. Unlike most of its kind, Xantine felt no base need to possess. Instead, the daemon seemed to be trying to make itself known, to parley. He tried to grab it, to take it in both hands and let out his rage, to feel it squirm and to crush it, to destroy its being entirely before casting the remnants down into the depths of his soul. But the daemon remained frustratingly out of reach. And then it spoke his name, using the same voice he had heard in his dream.

Suddenly he was back in Canticle City. The screaming of millions of slaves, the tectonic rumble of ten thousand spires collapsing, the apocalyptic roar of a Legion dying. He had been here countless times in his fugues, but this time was different. The sounds started to slow, mingling and flattening until they became a drone. A bass note, impossibly low, held until it stopped.

And then silence. Perfect silence. Xantine looked up, as he had done over and again, at the Tlaloc. It hung in the sky, a chunk of pure hatred.

Xantine.

That voice again, the one he had felt in his neck during his last dream. He felt it in his whole body now, his name washing against his skin like warm water.

He saw Euphoros, eyes still violet-tinged, rather than the pure black they were now, reflecting the burning Tlaloc's golden glow. He saw Vavisk, his mouth – his flesh-and-blood mouth – open in a scream. He knew what he would say next, he'd heard it many times before: 'To the ship, captain!' But no sound came.

Nothing moved.

Then *something* moved. A shape in the smoke, tall, thin and hazy, as if projected from somewhere far away. Xantine found it hard to focus on. The figure stepped forward, its long legs stepping over the rubble of the dying city as if it weren't there. Millennia of battle experience told him to back away from this unknown entity, to defend himself, but he found himself unable to move, as rooted to his position as the Tlaloc was frozen in the atmosphere above Canticle City.

A long neck reached up towards a face whose features swirled. There were eyes, he was sure, the impression of a flattened nose and sharp, feline teeth, but Xantine found he couldn't focus on the details. They flitted at the edge of comprehension, swimming and swirling together.

As he concentrated, they began to form more familiar shapes. He saw the faces of captains and soldiers, of Eidolon and Kaesoron, of those that died before the Emperor's Children's glorious ascension, and those that joined its ranks after Horus died at Terra.

He saw Epiales Kyr, his mouth formed into a feral whoop. He saw Gorenn, his ruined face and unblinking red eye. He saw Abaddon, the Despoiler's lip curled and his topknot tied, and his hand moved instinctively to the falchion that he kept at his hip. It wasn't there.

Finally, he saw himself. Bloodshot sclera and turquoise irises regarded exact copies of themselves with amusement.

'Daemon,' Xantine said. 'What are you?'

I am Xantine, the figure with his eyes said. It blinked, and its face changed. He saw rectangular pupils, black inset against soft purple.

And I am S'janth.

'What do you want?'

I want you. As I have always wanted you. And you want me. As you have always wanted me.

'I have.' It was meant as a question, but as it left his mouth, it became a statement.

I can give you what you want.

The figure with his eyes reached out, and Xantine felt its touch. It held a thousand promises: of pain and pleasure beyond compare, but most of all, of *power*. The power to destroy Euphoros, who betrayed him. To plunge a knife into the Black Legion, who tried to murder him. To strike out at his creator's Imperium, which denied him.

The figure with his eyes nestled close, so close that Xantine could feel its breath on his neck, even through his armour. ***Do you want me?***

‘Yes...’ he sighed.

Then come to me.

‘Where?’ he asked.

He saw black sands, a profane temple, and at its centre, a mirror and a sliver of ice.

On Kalliope, the figure breathed, soft as a whisper.

Xantine had been admitted to see Euphoros immediately upon his arrival at the warlord’s rehearsal chamber. Like the Living Gallery, the chamber once had a more practical use, as a briefing room. Previously the humans and Astartes of the Great Crusade used it to discuss and disseminate plans of attack.

Now Euphoros alone occupied it, using it to reflect on his decisions in the best way he knew: with an audience. Benches rose to the back of the room, affording a perfect view of the warlord as he paced the stage, offering commentary to a stoic Gorenn. In each of the benches was installed a still-living captive, their arms, legs and any additional appendages shorn off. Euphoros had taken care to ensure their senses remained intact, but he had removed their tongues, meaning that while he ostensibly offered his decisions up in front of a quorum for constructive criticism, nothing intelligible could come back from his macabre audience.

The moaning was orchestral, a symphony of wails, cries and gasps that pleased Xantine as he entered the chamber. Euphoros, he noted, became wary as he approached, as if his warlord was poised for censure for the slight of selecting a neophyte such as Kyr to lead the prestigious assault.

But Xantine had blindsided him, asking instead to lead the initial attack – the open blade. ‘Of course, my boy, you may have the honour!’ Euphoros had proclaimed, gleeful to have turned his wayward brother to the path of pragmatism. Gorenn, with his destroyed face and cyclopean eye, was unreadable. The Black Legionnaire tracked Xantine unerringly, the low rumble of his Terminator armour idling audible even over the sound of the groaning audience.

In the halcyon days of the Emperor’s Children, such an assault was a rapier strike, timed to perfection. But in Euphoros’ hands, with the heavily

limited resources of his warband, this version of the Maru Skara was like the Children of Torment themselves: a pale imitation of his Legion's former glory. Xantine knew he was offering to become little more than a glorified decoy, fodder for the Iron Hands to train their bolters on while Epiales Kyr, Euphoros' newest plaything, was given the pleasure of leading the attack's hidden blade.

But that didn't matter. His vision was no fleeting dream, he was sure of it. He had allowed hundreds, *thousands* of daemons to enter his body, and not once had the experience been like that. He knew S'janth was on Kalliope. He knew she was powerful beyond measure. All he needed to do was get to her, and together, they could achieve perfection.

He plotted the details, anyway, an easier process when all of the *Exhortation's* many distractions had been stripped away by his singular desire. Vavisk and his squad of Noise Marines would join the initial assault, their sonic weaponry providing a blanket of covering fire that would allow Xantine and his peers to charge the Iron Hands' position: a feint that would in turn allow for the hidden blade to deliver the killing cut. Striking from orbit, Kyr and his cohort would wait until Xantine's assault had forced the Iron Hands to cede control of their anti-air weaponry, allowing the vanguard to strike via Dreadclaw into the heart of the retreating Space Marines, catching them before they could filter back to their fortified positions inside the temple.

'It is an honour, my lords,' Xantine had said, bowing low before he departed for his Thunderhawk.

Vavisk had met him in the *Exhortation's* docking bay. His Noise Marines stood nearby, their sonic blasters hefted in hands that fused shining metal with flesh and bone. They communicated in squeals and blurts, fizzes and pops of static that set Xantine's skin crawling. The sensation reminded him of the voice in his dream, and he shivered with delight.

Vavisk fell in step alongside Xantine as he climbed the ramp to the craft, named *Kiss of the Void*, his heavy footfalls beating out a slow rhythm on the deck.

'Your song is different, brother,' Vavisk said. 'I can hear it rearrange. What will you play for us?'

'It is nothing, Vavisk. Euphoros has helped me to see the error of my ways, that is all.'

The mouths on Vavisk's throat moved as one.
'*Liar*,' they whispered.

The temple entrance rose out of black sand like a vast seashell, organic in shape, and pearlescent in the planet's high noon. Kalliope had once been an aeldari world. Euphoros had not said as much during his limited briefing, but Xantine recognised the form from the intricate statues that lined the stone pathway to the temple entrance. Once they must have been beautiful, even for profane xenos architecture, but millennia had blunted their features and broken their limbs. Now they rose from the black sand like the bones of a long-dead leviathan, bleaching in Kalliope's harsh sun.

Xantine knew the contingent of Iron Hands had made the temple their stronghold on the planet, but from such a distance, he couldn't discern their numbers.

'Diabolist,' he called over his armour vox. 'Show us what we face.'

Qaran Tun stepped forward, hands already working shapes against his rune-lined armour. His lips darkened as his ritual reached its crescendo, and a vial at his hip popped open. A shape, deeper black than both the dunes and charcoal armour of the Children of Torment, snaked down his leg and burrowed into the sand at his feet. The daemon whipped off at frightening speed towards the temple, while Tun – his eyes milky white – dropped to a knee and placed a hand to the black sand. After a moment, he spoke.

'I can see them, cousin.'

'Show me,' Xantine replied, and rested a hand on Tun's shoulder. At once, Xantine saw the temple through compound eyes. Iron Hands clustered in small groups, some with bolt rifles in firing positions, others manning tripod-mounted gun emplacements. Xantine knew the pattern from his grudging participation in Abaddon's Black Crusade – Firestrike turrets, a particular favourite of the freakishly large Primaris Marines. Xantine knew the risk of a frontal assault against such weaponry: he'd seen one Firestrike turret rip through more than two hundred cultists during the assault on Hive Tolstan, the drug-fuelled, silk-clad form reduced to a twitching mass of splintered bone and gobbets of meat. The turrets swivelled left and right now, their operators scanning the dunes for targets to train their accelerator autocannons on.

It was Primaris, he saw, that made up the majority of the Iron Hands. Their

armour was an oily black, almost camouflaged against the silken darkness of the sand dunes. From his daemon's-eye view, Xantine could see flashes of the aquila on their armour, a stark white that stood out against the black and gunmetal grey of their wargear. A hollow mockery of the eagle motif that Xantine and his fellow Emperor's Children once wore.

Xantine snarled. 'Vavisk.'

The Noise Marine stepped forward, his sonic blaster thrumming with barely contained power.

'Prepare your orchestra.'

Xantine's clawed boots dug at the sand as he sprinted for the enemy's line, sending flurries of dark dust into the air. The sonic assault and subsequent charge had surprised the Primaris Marines, but they were too well drilled to scatter. Squads dropped into established hardpoints, xenos masonry and airdropped adamantine barricades combined to provide the Iron Hands with cover while they assessed the incoming threat.

Other Primaris ran for the Firestrike turrets, their lumbering gait covering the shifting sands in seconds. These red-armoured warriors racked, loaded and fired their weapons with practised speed, loosing a *thunk-thunk-thunk* of autocannon shells at the onrushing Children of Torment. One such autocannon round took Ellamar in the shoulder as he charged alongside Xantine. The ancient warrior shrieked with laughter as he rolled with the impact, but the sound was cut short when another three rounds converged on his leather-masked head, pulping it entirely.

The trickle of incoming fire became a torrent as the entirety of the temple's garrison brought their bolt rifles to bear. Xantine ducked and weaved to avoid the stream of incoming shells, delighting in the kiss of pain as shrapnel pinged against his armour and exposed flesh. From the rear, Vavisk and his Noise Marines swept their sonic barrage across the Iron Hands' lines, the aural hellscape driving Space Marines from cover, their ears bleeding and their stomachs roiling.

He was close now – close enough that he could see the cold white aquila across the breast of two Primaris Marines as they shouldered their bolt rifles to fire. They never pulled their triggers, as a black shape rose from the sand, rearing up to twice their height. It closed around the closest Iron Hand's leg and contracted with a crunch, a sound both metallic and organic, before

retreating back into the sand. The maimed Space Marine stood on his remaining leg for a second, before momentum brought him to the ground. Xantine had a second to consider that the Iron Hand's wound wasn't spurting blood, but a thick black smoke, before the shape reared up again, wrapping itself around the wounded warrior's squad mate, thrashing him forward and back until his bones hung smashed in his armour.

'What a wonderful pet, Tun!' Xantine shouted, as he vaulted the barricade and fired a bolter round into the hobbled Space Marine's faceplate. He was met immediately by a chainsword, swung at head height by a third Primaris Marine. The blow was sent to decapitate him, but he spun on his heels and turned to face his assailant, falchion held point first in a duelling grip. The two warriors circled each other.

The Iron Hand stood a head taller than him. He was a breed of Space Marine ten thousand years newer than Xantine, and yet he was already more machine than transhuman. He braced on an adamantine leg, the dark metal ending in four splayed claws, pistons inside traversing up and down as he shifted his chainsword to a two-handed grip. The flesh of both arms ended at the elbow, the wrist and hands replaced with crude augmetics, segmented fingers still more than capable of crushing a skull.

'Die, traitor,' the Iron Hand said.

Xantine laughed, and shot the Iron Hand in the chest. The bolt shell hit its target, but – fired so close – deflected off the curved breastplate before detonating. Still, it startled the Iron Hand, and Xantine took advantage, smashing the hilt of his sword into his helmet. 'Traitor? New armour, new wargear, new monsters' – he cast a gaze up at the larger Primaris Marine – 'and still the same old epithets? How boring.'

He sliced once, twice, thrice, at the Iron Hand. The first two blows were feints, designed to intimidate and distract, but the third struck home, shaving a chunk of ceramite from the Iron Hand's shoulder armour. Xantine ducked out of his opponent's extended reach, his falchion's grip held back, the sword's point alongside his cheek. 'I am sure that your gene-meddling masters told you to say that, but consider for a moment. Am *I* truly the traitor here, child? Look at you.' Xantine straightened, casting the point of his sword the length of the taller warrior, from black-armoured boot to the top of his cybernetic head.

'You desecrate your flesh. You scrabble and claw to remove yourself from

your creator's form, to separate yourself from the species you claim to defend. I touch, I taste, I see, I *feel*. You give yourself to the cold machine, you subsume your senses, you blaspheme against your creator.'

The Iron Hand roared, a sound made cold in his machine throat. Xantine spun in response, whirling in high, low, then high again with his monomolecular blade. He scored another hit, his duellist's form allowing him to strike up across the aquila emblazoned on the taller warrior's armour.

'You wear that honour on your breast, and you know nothing of what it means. We alone earned it! Through perfection, we were judged the greatest, and we were afforded the highest honour by He who appointed Himself our judge. But we transcended even His control!'

Xantine was screaming now, and his earlier controlled strikes had given way to wilder swings. He slashed and slashed, not caring where his sword struck.

The chainsword took him in the side of the ribs. The teeth clanged off his charcoal plate, but the blow was hard, and it sent Xantine sprawling to the sand. The Iron Hand pressed the attack, bringing his chainsword down, two-handed, in a strike meant to hollow out his skull. Xantine caught the blow on his falchion, two hands holding the weapon at bay while its adamantite teeth sparked inches from his face.

'Die, traitor,' the Iron Hand said again, his voice infuriatingly devoid of emotion. Xantine panted, muscles stretched to breaking point by the Primaris Marine's terrible strength. He prepared himself for agony: both the pain of death, and the ignominy of dying to such an opponent. He reached inside his mind as the blow was readied... and felt the lightest of touches. Soft and silken, waves of pleasure travelled across his body, rejuvenating him in a moment.

Now, something said. Xantine reversed the sword in his hands and thrust upwards, spearing the Primaris Marine through his aquila-adorned chestplate. He leapt forward as the larger Space Marine toppled backwards, ending his strike crouched over his foe.

He whooped, exhilaration coursing through his ragged nerves. 'We are still the greatest of all of us, newblood. Remind your father of that, when you meet him!'

Xantine twisted his blade and pulled it back out of the Iron Hand's ruined

chest, bringing sparking circuitry with it.

The battle continued around him. To his left, Lordling was bent over the corpse of another Primaris in black, cackling to himself as he pulled ropes of gore-slick intestine and deposited them on the hot sand. To his right, Tun crouched low, the Colchisian runes on his armour swirling and glowing as he whispered words of encouragement and direction to his Neverborn charges. Iron Hands moved in groups, as precise and machine-like as he'd expected from sons of the Gorgon, their resolve not yet wavering. But the turrets were quiet, their occupants either slain or retreating to safer positions. Now to deliver the killing blow.

'Kyr,' Xantine called over the vox. 'The first strike is made.'

A roar in the sky. Xantine's neck snapped upwards, and he saw black specks, each trailing yellow-and-red fire. They looked like tiny versions of the Tlaloc, Xantine thought, as the specks turned into black masses, growing like cancer. Kyr's Dreadclaws were on their way.

They shook the ground as they slammed down, causing statues – eroded by years of sandstorms – to collapse with the force of the impact. The Dreadclaws' doors swung open, chipped and heat-stained black ceramite giving way to a new wave of darkness that spilled out with Kyr at its head. The newcomers had the perfect position from which to cut off the Iron Hands' retreat, but rather than move to the temple's oval doors to cut them off, Xantine was appalled to see Epiales Kyr lead his warriors back out to the blood-slick sands to mop up survivors.

'No, you fool!' Xantine shouted.

The newcomers fell upon the wounded Iron Hands. Kyr whirled, glaive flashing in the light of Kalliope's twin suns. He brought the blade down across an arm, severing it at the wrist. Its owner stared for a second, captivated by the pulsing spray of blood that filled the air where his hand had been, before Kyr preserved his baffled expression forever by separating his head from his shoulders. Another Iron Hand tried to catch Kyr from behind with a chainsword held in a two-handed grip, but he turned on the spot, flashing his glaive in an arc that first deflected the blow, before tearing across the Primaris Marine's stomach armour. The taller warrior froze as the blade bit home, before slumping to the blood-slick sand, split across the gut.

It was art, Xantine knew, but it wasn't the perfection of the Maru Skara. Kyr had foregone the bliss of a surgical strike in favour of messy, ragged

sensation, choosing to bathe in the blood of the broken and the dying, rather than break the back of their enemy's forces.

The last of the surviving Iron Hands made it through the oval opening, and huge doors rolled shut. The hidden blade had missed its target.

With no other path into the aeldari temple, Kyr, still blood-drunk from his rampage on the sands, had ordered his squad to fire on the structure to carve a path inside. To his screaming frustration, the wraithbone – flexible and organic to the touch, but as resistant as ceramite to damage – had withstood the fusillade.

Kyr took instead to stabbing at the edifice, using chainswords purloined from his most recent kills to carve chunks out of the black material. Finally, when that didn't work, he began to beat his fists against it, shrieking louder and more creative curses with each smack.

Xantine waited until his rival's lusts retreated, and signalled to Vavisk. With a croak of static, the Noise Marines turned as one, levelling their sonic blasters towards the door. The ornate cannons spooled up slowly, the sound rising in both pitch and volume until it reached a crescendo. For Xantine, even standing close to the weapons was almost too much to bear. He wavered on the edge, between agony and ecstasy, reminded of the death scream of Canticle City.

Reality buckled where the barrage combined, opening small rents to the warp that let through the smallest and basest Neverborn to wriggle and writhe on the hot sand. Gobbets of flesh, tips of tentacles, disembodied mouths with lips that smacked and quivered on their own. Long fingers, questing tongues; blind, groping things called towards the impossible, beautiful sound.

The bone door had resisted blade and bolter, but under the Noise Marines' weaponised drone it began to crack. It splintered along organic lines, weaknesses showing like veins of blood along its surface, until it reached breaking point and bowed inwards. It hung for a moment, a bone about to fracture, before it shattered, sending shards the size of Space Marines and plumes of dust into the space the door had protected.

The wide pathway beyond dropped down a short distance before it ended unexpectedly, its span blocked by vast chunks of alien stonework. Xantine crouched next to a chunk of debris, running an armoured finger across its

edge. It was rock splintered from the temple's roof, but its edges were soft, not sharp, with bubbles and spheres showing it had been superheated. It was the work of melta charges, and Xantine didn't need helmet runes to show him the rock was cold and long solidified. The Iron Hands had blockaded this passage hours, if not days before. But of the squads they had just been fighting, there was no sign. That meant one thing: there was another way down.

Kyr prowled in front of the barricade, whooping and yelping as he slashed at the largest hunks of rock. Xantine ignored him, and called for the diabolist. 'Tun,' he said, his voice low. 'Can one of your pets find our entrance?'

The Word Bearer sighed and crouched again, pulling a finger-sized bottle from a skin pouch at his hip. Qaran Tun levered the stopper off and whispered something to the bottle's contents, his lips turning ash-black as he spoke. A pink thing wormed its way out of the container, mewling and flailing at the air before dropping onto the sandy ground. It writhed helplessly for a moment, before it seemed to age in seconds, its fleshy mass darkening and sprouting a forest of waving cilia. Finally ready for its task, it jerked itself to the nearest wall and hit it with a sickening thump, working its way around the edges of the space, picking, prodding and poking at holes in the alien structure. It eventually stopped at a portion of wall far off to the left of the space, trying to attract its master's attention by slapping wetly against the otherwise unremarkable surface.

Xantine moved to the creature, levered it gently from its resting place, and knocked at the surface with a closed fist. He was rewarded with a metallic sound, and he tapped again, exploring the edges of the wall. Carefully concealed behind a facade of alien stone, he realised, was a hatch: a hinged metal plate, constructed with the cold precision the machine-obsessed Iron Hands were infamous for. These Primaris whelps were poor imitations of their long-dead primarch, Xantine thought, but they did seem to share some of his affinity for craftsmanship. He was almost impressed. He ran a finger across the camouflaged surface and turned to Vavisk. At a nod, the Noise Marine's sonic blaster thrummed to life, filling the space with a blessed hum that set Xantine's filed teeth on edge.

When the roar died in the chamber, there was nothing left of the hatch but a ragged hole in the wall. Kyr, his focus drawn by the sonic blast, was first

through, shrieking in triumph as he disappeared inside.

Following at a saunter, Xantine had to duck to step into the ragged hole, his ornate pauldrons scraping on hard rock and leaving trails of gold leaf. He grimaced. The corridor – which seemed to run in parallel with the blocked main passage – was barely tall enough to admit one Space Marine, but the Iron Hands had definitely come this way. Bolt casings and magazines lay strewn along the path where the Primaris Marines had reloaded their bolt rifles as they fled, their bootprints in the tracked-in sand suggesting a fast, but orderly, retreat further into the temple.

Kyr, having muscled his way into the passage first, led the party, though more out of hunger for his prey than any sense of command responsibility. With each hint of the Primaris' progress, he moved faster, until he was sprinting down the widening passage, shrieking as he ran, his plume trailing behind his lithe form like a comet's tail.

'The *hidden* blade, is it?' Xantine asked, under his breath, before placing his falchion in its scabbard and breaking out into his own, more measured run. Lordling, lumbering his bulk along nearby, grinned quizzically at the statement, his stubby legs pumping hard to keep up. They ran until the path grew even wider, large enough to admit four abreast of the remaining warriors of the Maru Skara – Xantine, Lordling, Qaran Tun, Vavisk and three of his Noise Marines, as well as Kyr and the majority of his squad of Black Legionnaires. Kyr led the way, stopping only when the corridor reached its end point, the ceiling now lost to unaugmented sight.

Xantine followed Kyr into the new space: a vast chamber, easily wide and tall enough to allow the entry of a Warhound Titan. The path continued forward, bracketed by pairs of huge pillars, each topped with a statue. Unlike their battered brethren outside, these statues stood complete, having avoided the destructive power of Kalliope's sandstorms.

They depicted warriors in segmented armour, almost human in shape, but too slender, too tall, too alien. Xantine tasted revulsion on his tongue and enjoyed the flavour, remembering the aeldari he had gutted and the peculiar taste of their flesh. He allowed himself to hope he might taste such rare meat again today, but the apparent age of the temple and Kalliope's position so close to the Eye likely meant the ancient race had long departed the world, leaving this temple as... As what?

The room was lit by a soft glow, too organic to be the Imperium's lumens,

too stable to be warp lights. In the light, Xantine could see runes carved into the base of each plinth. They were smooth and precise, obviously lacking the arcane power of Cthonic, Nostraman or Colchisian script, but Xantine asked the diabolist anyway, gesturing up with his falchion at the feet of the statues.

‘Vile aeldari nonsense,’ Tun replied. ‘Given the species, it could be a site of worship, or of memorial. It could be...’

Xantine. Free me.

The voice was close. So close, and so sad, that suddenly he understood.

‘It’s a prison,’ Xantine said. When viewed in order, he realised, the statues told a story. It started with great sorrow, depicted by a robed and hooded figure – a warrior, by the long spear it clutched – crouched in abject despair. The next statue showed that despair turning to terror, the warrior now in full flight, pursued by some unseen monster. Another set of statues hinted at resolve, as though the warrior had a plan to ensnare its tormentor.

And the last statue showed both triumph and tragedy. The figure, its head contained within a bulbous helmet, knelt low, its body held in state by a vast spear that pierced its chest. The spear ran through the figure, all the way to the floor, where it was tipped with a shining barb, long enough and thin enough for an aeldari warrior to wield in two hands.

Or a Space Marine.

‘The spear.’

The daemon inside the vessel had been just an emissary, a sliver of being. Xantine knew that the true power of S’janth was bound in that spear. He could be with her. He just needed to get to it first, before Kyr.

‘What did you say, cousin?’ Qaran Tun asked, before the bolts took him in the back. They blew the Word Bearer off his feet and sent him sprawling against the foot of the nearest plinth. The force of their impact so close blasted Xantine forward too, but he managed to twist as he fell, coming up in a roll and sliding his armoured frame against a wraithbone wall.

The attack had been timed with precision: Xantine watched from cover as Kyr’s Black Legionnaires withered under the Iron Hands’ unerringly accurate bolt-rifle shots. One, a disciple of the Blood God by his bellicose bearing, roared his defiance, twin chainswords whirring in blood-soaked hands. He was rewarded with a bolt shell to the face. His chainswords dropped to the floor, skittering and biting through masonry and gobbets of

their owner's brain matter as they kept up their service in his dead hands. Another in old Mark IV plate, his shoulder decorated with the blood-red eye of Horus, was shot through the chest from at least four different angles, the bolts detonating in his organs and ensuring he was dead before he hit the ground.

Kyr was quicker off the mark, and ducked the first outpouring of fire, flipping between cover with a dancer's grace. Xantine, too, had avoided the initial salvo, and made for the slumped figure of Qaran Tun. He crouched down low to inspect the damage, noting that the Word Bearer had a hole in his stomach armour where the bolts had impacted. Blood oozed out, dark against his black plate, but it was already clotting, and millennia of experience told him it wasn't life-threatening. Xantine reached down, and Tun opened his eyes. 'Your concern is touching, cousin,' he said, reaching forward to be helped to his feet.

Xantine batted his hand away and reached instead for the diabolist's belt, drawing a small, shuddering container forth and bringing it up to his face. He slid the top off, and before the daemon inside could escape, he closed his mouth around it. This time, he didn't wait for the Neverborn to wander into his trap – he pulled the creature into his mind, extracting its limited power and adding it to his own.

Energised, he looked over to the spear, resting at the foot of the statue at the far end of the chamber. He steeled himself, and scanned his surroundings. The sound of the Iron Hands' methodical bolter fire had not slowed, but the chorus was quieter now, as Kyr and his squad wreaked havoc among the remaining warriors of the Imperium. The slice of blades against armour, the grind of chainswords and the screams of dying Space Marines were music to Xantine's ears.

But there was another sound, too. A rhythmic clomping, growing louder – a bass note that shook the dust from the ancient statues and vibrated his eyes in their sockets. It was joined by the spooling up of a gatling cannon as a Redeptor Dreadnought shouldered through carved stonework, blocking his path to the spear.

'Your flesh... is weak,' it rumbled through its vox-unit, levelling its gatling cannon at Xantine. Six barrels spun faster as the weapon's autoloader cycled ammunition into the breech.

Kyr leapt from above, landing atop the Dreadnought with his legs

straddling its sarcophagus. 'I shall melt your body and drink your blood!' he screamed. The intervention threw the machine forward, and its gatling shells missed their mark, churning up the stone at Xantine's feet. The machine stumbled, but righted itself quickly, reaching up with its articulated hand to grab at Kyr's leg, before pulling him down to the ground.

The Black Legionnaire turned the tumble into a graceful tuck and roll, coming up alongside Xantine, their backs against the temple wall. Kyr turned to look at Xantine, his helmet's eye-lenses burning magenta in the gloom. 'The open blade and the hidden blade, combined at the end, brother! The perfect strike!' Kyr screamed, his vox-unit distorting. 'Join me in glory!'

Xantine turned and slashed in one motion, drawing his falchion across the back of Kyr's legs. The curved blade bit deep into the joints behind his knee, slicing skin and separating muscle and tendon from bone. Epiales Kyr slumped to the floor, shock for once rendering him silent.

'Imbecile, what do you know of perfection?' Xantine said, as he backed away from his stricken rival.

The Dreadnought's fist closed around Kyr, lifting him from the temple floor with almost tender precision, like a child scooping a baby bird that had fallen from its nest. Taking the opportunity, Xantine ran towards the Dreadnought's vast chassis, sliding at the last moment between its legs, before sprinting for the back of the chamber.

Kyr lashed out, his plume flicking arcs of colour as his sword-hand rose and fell. The blade sparked against the Redeemptor's shoulder armour, carving furrows into the white-painted ceramite, but unable to cut through to the vital machinery beneath. Kyr shrieked and shrieked, curses and promises spilling from a constricted throat. The Dreadnought squeezed, and Kyr burst, a wet sound that echoed off the temple walls. His arms fell slack, his blade dropped to the floor where it bounced on its end, before settling with a rattle. His legs, already slack, followed the sword, trailing entrails and a broken spinal column forming a perverse imitation of his extravagant helmet plumage.

The Dreadnought spun on its waist axis and fired, gatling-cannon shells tearing chunks out of the alien stonework, but Xantine was beyond its turning arc, moving fast and using the debris as cover.

'Vavisk!' Xantine screamed over the vox. 'Kill the machine!'

He only received a bass rumble in reply, but from scattered positions, Xantine once again heard the music of the apocalypse begin its chorus, and saw the Redeptor's armour start to dent and buckle.

Xantine, the voice called, so loud that he could hear it over the din of the Noise Marines, so aching that he thought he would die to deliver it a moment of pleasure.

'I'm coming, my love,' he whispered as he ran.

He ran for the spear, letting his falchion clatter to the temple floor as he reached its resting place. The spear vibrated with power, begging to be touched. He reached out a gloved hand, allowed his fingers to close around the haft, and bared his soul to the daemon. A shape rose from the spear, winding around his arm, its touch deliciously cold and chased through with slivers of pain. It reached his shoulders, wound around his neck. He gasped slightly, his jaw slackening, and the shape slipped into his open mouth, tracing a taste of agony against his tongue as it tumbled down his throat.

He was used to sharing his body with small, skittering things, morsels to devour. Compared to them, S'janth was a supernova. She bore down on his consciousness as bright and terrible as the Tlaloc over Canticle City, but where that brought only destruction, she promised life. Sensation. *Power*.

At last, the voice said. It was his own voice, he realised. **We are together.**

He saw an aeon of pain and pleasure, and then – so much worse – an eternity of *nothing*. An awful fate for a being of perfect sensation. He drank deep from her pain, tasting a stronger agony than his mortal form could imagine. He pulled hungrily at her pleasure at finally being freed from her immortal captivity. He saw her long-dead aeldari captors, tricksters and clowns, and *hated* them for shackling one so beautiful. She spoke in his mind.

Thank you, she said.

The Dreadnought turned again, the Noise Marines driven off, and its focus returned to the enemy at its rear. Gatling-cannon shells spat from its right arm, but Xantine was faster and stronger than he'd ever been, now S'janth was sharing his soul. He felt no pain, no fatigue, no hesitation. His muscles swelled, his bones felt feather-light. His senses were open beyond the transhuman level – the world of Kalliope seemed in sharper focus, Xantine somehow conscious of minute movements across the vast chamber before

they even happened. He ran, dodging fire with preternatural speed, and leapt, spear braced against his shoulder, to drive the tip clean through the front of the Redeptor's sarcophagus.

With a strength even his warp-touched body hadn't possessed before, he yanked the spear out of the Dreadnought, before plunging it back in, deep. The weapon ripped through ceramite until it found the soft form of the mangled body held in amniotic fluid at its heart.

'The flesh... is weak...' the Dreadnought's vox-unit croaked, its fluids dribbling out of the rents in its frame. Xantine barked a laugh, dropping to the temple floor. 'Yours was. Mine has never been stronger,' he said. He saw the machine's warning lumens fizzle and fade, saw the great power fist slacken, and then the Dreadnought toppled to the ground with a crash.

The machine, like the remaining Iron Hands, was dead. But S'janth was not finished – not after millennia separated from both the warp and realspace. The daemon puppeted his limbs, climbing him onto the Dreadnought's chassis and striking the spear again, again and again, until Xantine crouched amid a pool of thick black blood and foul-smelling machine oils that had bubbled from the rents in the Dreadnought's armour. Soon she cast the spear aside, scratching with Xantine's hands at the openings in the ceramite, pulling out handfuls of cold grey flesh. She devoured them hungrily, Xantine's teeth barely having time to chew before she swallowed the chunks of flesh almost whole, choking them down his throat like a snake.

The taste, the taste! she moaned, and Xantine felt his soul cower from the terrible, beautiful sound. ***It has been so long, SO LONG,*** S'janth cried.

And then Xantine was falling, down into the deep places of his soul where he kept his broken playthings, as control of his body was taken from him – not willingly, this time, but by force.

He awoke as *Kiss of the Void* began docking procedures with the *Exhortation*. He had been dreaming of Canticle City again, he knew, but this time there was no daemon. There was no Euphoros, no Vavisk, either. That was strange. For the first time, Xantine had watched as the Tlaloc came down on his city and himself, had felt his soul wash away into the warp as his body was reduced to atoms by the nuclear firestorm. S'janth, sated for a time after so long in captivity, was quiet in his mind.

Gorenn had returned to the *Shattered Blade*, but Euphoros still called a banquet. The event was a tradition that stretched back to before the destruction of Canticle City: a celebration of a successful raid, and the chance to revel in the spoils. The relics and weapons plundered from the temple lay strewn across the table, the silver spear resting alongside a beetle-black breastplate, a bandolier of spheroid grenades and a small collection of ancient shuriken weaponry. But it was Epiales Kyr who was given pride of place at the table. Silver bowls hissed and popped with his fluids, what little slaves were able to extract from his mangled corpse combined with powerful narcotics to make beverages that the banquet's guests sampled with relish, sipping daintily or gulping thirstily at the essence of Kyr's life. These bowls were secondary to the table's centrepiece, though: atop a golden platter heaped high with entrails was Kyr's head, his eyes half-popped from their sockets and red with burst blood vessels. Dried blood crusted on his cheeks where it had trickled from his ears. His mouth had the same pained expression that it had displayed in his moment of destruction.

Even in death, he still usurped Xantine.

Slaves carried delicacies from below-decks kitchens in their own stomachs, their steps staggered and their expressions pained until they were able to regurgitate them into the gold and ivory bowls held by their masters. Euphoros lifted such a bowl as he called a toast.

'To our brother, gone to glory!' Euphoros said, and aimed a toast at Kyr's head, guzzling and guzzling while the liquid – still steaming – cascaded from the corners of his mouth.

'And to those brothers who returned with stories and spoils to share.' Euphoros gestured to Xantine, who took a cup of wine as thick as blood from a slave. He held the cup in his hand, and raised it to Euphoros. 'My most humble apologies, my lord. I can only prostrate myself in front of your magnificence for my failure in allowing Kyr to be killed.'

'Your failure?' Euphoros exclaimed, a fatherly tone in his voice. 'The failure was mine, my boy! I should have known better than to have Kyr deliver the killing cut. Now drink!'

Xantine put the cup to his mouth and sucked it dry, the sickly-sweet liquid coating his tongue and throat in a hollow simulacrum of S'janth's entry into his soul. Still the daemon lay dormant in his consciousness. Already, he

missed her touch.

‘It should have been you, my boy,’ Euphoros continued. ‘You are still of the old Legion. You wield the hidden blade with more subtlety and skill than any one of us.’ The warlord’s smile was wide. ‘Any one of us... but for me.’

Xantine’s skin prickled as he felt ice slip through his veins. His twin hearts slowed, and his arms felt heavy.

‘Do you like the wine, Xantine? It’s a rare vintage indeed, made only by the Youngest God’s handmaidens. It heightens the senses, but deadens the body. Even a body as beautiful as yours, swarming as it is with countless souls, is not immune to its power. I won’t tell you what I had to sacrifice to get it, but rest assured you are honoured indeed, my boy.’ Euphoros stood over him now, a jewelled knife in his hand. He leant forward and traced it along the line of Xantine’s chin.

Xantine tried to reply, but with his body paralysed, he could only grunt.

‘You know why I chose Kyr to lead the hidden blade, Xantine? Because I could trust him. He was a simpleton, a shrieking fool, lost to sensation, and he would do whatever I told him, as long as I could provide for his basest instincts. Not like you,’ Euphoros continued. He was gesticulating, talking not only to Xantine but to a captive audience of guests at the banquet, each of whom was rooted to the spot as they waited to see what their leader would do.

‘The aeldari found something on Kalliope. Something old, something beautiful, something perfect, and they bound it, imprisoned it, enslaved it.’ Euphoros narrowed his eyes as he talked. ‘Abaddon’s Legion is the power in the galaxy now. With such a gift, I could surely secure a place at the Warmaster’s right hand.’ He pointed to the spear.

‘But you soiled that gift, did you not, my boy? And so, if I cannot have it...’ The warlord pulled his jewelled blade back, and raised a sabre, mirror black, angled to deliver a blow that would cut Xantine’s throat.

The blast of sound lifted Euphoros from his feet, launching him across the banquet table. Vavisk stood, his sonic blaster raised, and Xantine looked up at the face of his saviour.

For the first time, he saw the truth.

It had been Vavisk at Canticle City, lifting the masonry from his crushed legs. Vavisk who pulled Xantine to his feet and carried him to the escape

craft. Vavisk who waved off Euphoros, as the younger officer, his face still regal in bearing, pleaded his case.

'Leave him, Vavisk!' Euphoros had screamed as the world died.

Vavisk. His captain. His *brother*.

Ah, S'janth breathed, her presence suddenly bright and beautiful in his mind. ***It has been so long since I felt... that.*** Starved of sensation in captivity, she took nourishment from Xantine's memory. His eyes fluttered open as he felt her sweet caress, his limbs spasming as she used her power to cleanse them of toxins. He stood from his chair and took the silver spear from the table.

Euphoros' black eyes radiated shock as he drew himself to his feet, scrambling away from his rejuvenated subordinate. 'I heard the same call you did, Xantine!' Euphoros screamed. 'I did not tell you, or Kyr, or even Gorenn what that temple held. I didn't know myself, but I heard its song, plaintive and powerful beyond measure. I know that it lives inside you now.'

A lie, S'janth whispered, words sweet in his mind. ***I only sing for you, Xantine. For us.***

Xantine shook his head, and Euphoros' tone – previously plaintive – changed to one of venom. 'You have eaten *so many* souls, Xantine, but even for one so gluttonous as you, this one will be your undoing.'

The warlord lunged forward to deliver a killing blow, but his black sabre was met by Xantine's silver spear. The two Emperor's Children fell apart, before coming together again, again and again, their weapons issuing sparks and hissing smoke where they joined in the cloying air of the Living Gallery.

They were duelling as they had before their Legion's fall, Xantine noted with wry amusement – two perfect demonstrations of blade work, even after all these centuries. But where Euphoros was tiring, the poison was still only now leaving Xantine's system, its malign influence replaced in his nerves and muscles by S'janth's sublime power.

He pressed the attack, and Euphoros was forced to abandon his own strikes and focus on deflecting the spear's thrusts, parrying the weapon until – at last – he could only catch the spear tip on his sabre, arresting a killing blow before it tore into his throat.

'She will consume you, Xantine,' Euphoros said, his voice rasping with

the effort of holding the spear.

The hidden blade, S'janth whispered.

Xantine brought his falchion up in his left hand, whipping it in a backhanded blow delivered with daemoniac speed. The cut bisected Euphoros' jaw completely, sending the top of his skull spinning across the banquet table. It landed, teeth up, on a gilded serving platter, facing Kyr's own decapitated head in perfect contrast. Chunks of pink brain matter and oily blood formed a perverse garnish.

The roar from the banquet's guests was terrible to hear – a sound of bloodlust and betrayal, of pain and pleasure – but Xantine paid it no heed. He had already given himself to S'janth. Kyr's coterie and Euphoros' loyalists howled curses and leapt forward to challenge Xantine, but the daemon was in control now, and she cut them all down. She killed a mutant in Black Legion plate, his left arm a chitinous crab claw, disembowelling him with a single strike. She tore the life from Surelio Vantire, once of the Third, piercing his two hearts with two blades.

In S'janth's control, Xantine's body twirled, faster than he thought possible, the spear stabbing and slicing until it was a silver blur interrupted only by arcs of vermillion blood. Slaves ran and were scythed down; servitors, their lobotomised brains woefully incapable of understanding the imminent danger, were split in two.

The massacre continued until Xantine stood on the dais, spear held behind his back like a scorpion's tail, panting like a dying dog. Around him lay the corpses of his brothers and cousins: Emperor's Children, Black Legionnaires and heretics of all banners. A handful remained. Vavisk, his flesh-and-metal face unreadable. Lordling, as amused by the slaughter as he always was. And Qaran Tun, too, observing the carnage with a scholar's mien.

Xantine stood atop the dais, alone in the seat of power for his butchered warband. Xantine, alone. Finally.

Not alone. The sound in his head was the sweetest music he'd ever heard, like the secrets of the universe unveiled, like the Youngest God's orchestra, playing just for him.

S'janth was laughing. *He* was laughing. The sound boomed from his mouth, each staccato peal rattling bone cutlery on the banquet table and the

paintings on the walls. Blood soaked every inch of the plush furnishings.

Look what we can have, Xantine. Your warband, its command in your grasp. Your Legion, unshackled once more, the most perfect creations of the most imperfect being.

‘See me, my brothers and slaves! I am perfection! We are perfection! We are the Third, and we will no longer be shackled to our murderer’s side.’

Xantine and S’janth roared in unison.

‘The phoenix is rising again!’

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Rich McCormick is a writer and videogame producer whose love affair with the worlds of Warhammer began when he was handed a small plastic ork at a very tender age. He used to live in Japan, but now he lives in Yorkshire, with his wife and son. 'Knife Flight' is his first story for Black Library.

An extract from *Fabius Bile: Primogenitor*.



Oleander Koh strode across the dead city, humming softly to himself.

The dry wind scraped across his garishly painted power armour, and he hunched forward, leaning into the teeth of the gale. He relished the way it flayed his exposed skin. He licked at the blood that dripped down his face, savouring the spice of it.

Oleander's demeanour was at once baroque and barbaric. It was fitting, given that he had left a trail of fire and corpses stretching across centuries. His power armour was the colour of a newly made bruise, and decorated with both obscene imagery and archaic medicae equipment. Animal skins flapped from the rims of his shoulder-plates, and a helmet crested with a ragged mane of silk strips dangled from his equipment belt, amongst the stasis-vials and extra clips of ammunition for the bolt pistol holstered opposite the helmet. Besides the pistol, his only weapon was a long, curved sword. The sword was Tuonela-made, forged in the secret smithy of the mortuary cults, and its golden pommel was wrought in the shape of a death's head. Oleander was not its first owner, nor, he suspected, would he be its last.

Unlike the weapon, he had been forged on Terra. As Apothecary Oleander, he had marched beneath the banners of the Phoenician, fighting first in the Emperor's name and then in the Warmaster's. He had tasted the fruits of war, and found his purpose in the field-laboratories of the being he'd come to call master. The being he had returned to this world to see, though he risked death, or worse, for daring to do so.

He had been forced to land the gunship he'd borrowed some distance away, on the outskirts of the city. It sat hidden now among the shattered husks of hundreds of other craft, its servitor crew waiting for his signal.

There was no telling what sort of defences had been erected in his absence. And while he'd sent a coded vox transmission ahead, asking for permission to land, he didn't feel like taking the risk of being blown out of the sky by someone with an itchy trigger-finger. The few occupants of this place valued their privacy to an almost lunatic degree. But perhaps that was only natural, given their proclivities.

His ceramite-encased fingers tapped out a tuneless rhythm on the sword's pommel as he walked and hummed. The wind screamed as it washed over him. And not just the wind. The whole planet reverberated with the death-scream of its once-proud population. Their delicate bones carpeted the ground, fused and melted together, though not from a natural heat. If he listened, he could pick out individual strands from the cacophony, like notes from a song. It was as if they were singing just for him. Welcoming him home.

The remains of the city – their city – rose wild around him, a jungle of living bone and wildly growing hummocks of rough psychoplastic flesh. The city might have been beautiful once, but it was gorgeous now. Silent, alien faces clumped on wraithbone walls like pulsing fungi, and living shadows stretched across the streets. Eerie radiances glistened in out-of-the-way places and tittering, phosphorescent shapes skulked in the broken buildings. A verdant madness, living and yet dead. A microcosm of Urum, as a whole.

Urum the Dead-Alive. Crone world, some called it. Urum was not its original name. But it was what the scavengers of the archaeomarkets called it, and it was as good a name as any. For Oleander Koh, it had once simply been 'home'.

Sometimes it was hard to remember why he'd left in the first place. At other times, it was all too easy. Idly, he reached up to touch the strand of delicate glass philtres hanging from around his thick neck. He stopped. The wind had slackened, as if in anticipation. Oleander grunted and turned. Something was coming. 'Finally,' he said.

Gleaming shapes streaked towards him through the ruins. They shone like metal in the sunlight, but nothing made of metal could move so smoothly or so fast. At least nothing he'd ever had the misfortune to meet. They'd been stalking him for a few hours now. Perhaps they'd grown bored with the game. Or maybe he was closer to his goal than he'd thought. The city

changed year by year, either growing or decaying. He wasn't sure which. Perhaps both.

The sentry-beasts were low, lean things. He thought of wolves, though they weren't anything like that. More akin to the sauroids that inhabited some feral worlds, albeit with feathers of liquid metal rather than scales, and tapering beak-like jaws. They made no noise, save the scraping of bladed limbs across the ground. They split up, and vanished into the shadows of the ruins. Even with his transhuman senses, Oleander was hard-pressed to keep track of them. He sank into a combat stance, fingers resting against the sword's hilt, and waited. The moment stretched, seconds ticking by. The wind picked up, and his head resounded with the screams of the dead.

He sang along with them for a moment, his voice rising and falling with the wind. It was an old song, older even than Urum. He'd learned it on Laeran, from an addled poet named Castigne. 'Strange is the night where black stars rise, and strange moons circle through ebon skies... songs that the Hyades shall sing...'

Prompted by instinct, Oleander spun, his sword springing into his hand as if of its own volition. He cut the first of the beasts in two, spilling its steaming guts on the heaving ground. It shrieked and kicked at the air, refusing to die. He stamped on its skull until it lay still. Still singing, he turned. The second had gone for the high ground. He caught a glimpse of it as it prowled above him, stalking through the canopy of bone and meat. He could hear its jagged limbs clicking as it moved. His hand dropped to his pistol.

Something scraped behind him. 'Clever,' he murmured. He drew the bolt pistol and whirled, firing. A shimmering body lurched forward and collapsed. Oleander twirled his sword and thrust it backwards, to meet the second beast as it leapt from its perch. Claws scrabbled at his power armour, and curved jaws snapped mindlessly. Its eyes were targeting sensors, sweeping his face for weakness. Oleander stepped back and slammed the point of his sword into one of the twisted trees, dislodging the dying animal.

He prodded the twitching creature with his weapon. It was not a natural thing, with its gleaming feathers and sensor nodes jutting from its flesh like spines. But then, this was not a natural world. The sentry-beast had been

vat-grown, built from base acids, stretched and carved into useful shape. Idly, he lifted the blade and sampled the acrid gore that stained it. 'Piquant,' he said. 'With just a hint of the real thing. Your best work yet, master.'

Oleander smiled as he said it. He hadn't used that word in a long time. Not since he'd last been here. Before Urum's master, and his, had exiled him for his crimes. Oleander shied away from the thought. Reflecting on those last days was like probing an infected wound, and his memories were tender to the touch. There was no pleasure to be had there, only pain. Some adherents of Slaanesh claimed that those things were ever one and the same, but Oleander knew better.

He kicked the still-twitching body and turned away. Something rattled nearby. The sentry-beasts made no noise, save for that peculiar clicking of their silvery carapace. More of them burst out of the unnatural undergrowth and converged on him. Foolish, to think there were only three. Excess was a virtue here, as everywhere. 'Well, he who hesitates is lost,' he said, lunging to meet them. There were ten, at least, though they were moving so swiftly it was hard to keep count.

Beak-like protuberances fastened on his armour as he waded through them. Smooth talon-like appendages scraped paint from the ceramite, and whip-like tails thudded against his legs and chest. They were trying to knock him down. He brought his sword down and split one of the quicksilver shapes in half. Acidic ichor spewed upwards. He fired his bolt pistol, the explosive rounds punching fist-sized holes in his attackers.

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